FREE PRINTABLE

Make Your House Smell Amazing

Ten methods with the exact recipe for each, where it works, and what to watch out for. From a thirty second shower trick to a diffuser that runs six weeks.

Pick one method per room rather than running everything at once. The simmer pot is the one to try first if you are only trying one.

METHOD 1

Linen and room spray

HOW

- 1 cup distilled water
- 2 tablespoons vodka or 91 percent rubbing alcohol
- 18 to 20 drops essential oil, lavender and orange together is a good pair
- Shake hard before every use, mist from about a foot away

WHERE IT WORKS

Curtains, bedding, upholstery. A soft scent close to the fabric, dry in a minute.

WATCH OUT

Not on silk or dry clean only fabric. Test a hidden patch on new furniture. Cap it at 20 drops per cup.

METHOD 2

Stovetop simmer pot

HOW

- A small saucepan of water
- 1 sliced orange, 3 or 4 cinnamon sticks, 1 tablespoon whole cloves, 2 sprigs rosemary
- Lowest heat, bare simmer, top up the water every 30 to 45 minutes
- Summer version: sliced lemon, a handful of mint, 1 teaspoon vanilla

WHERE IT WORKS

The whole floor. The steam rides the airflow through the house. Cool, cover and keep in the fridge for up to three days of reheating.

WATCH OUT

Never leave it unattended and never let it boil dry. It masks, so deal with the source of a smell first.

METHOD 3

Baking soda jars

HOW

- Half fill small jars or ramekins with baking soda
- 8 to 10 drops essential oil, stirred through with a fork
- Cover with muslin and a rubber band
- Stir every few days, replace every two to three weeks

WHERE IT WORKS

Under bathroom sinks, by the kitchen trash, the coat closet, the mudroom. Removes the stale baseline rather than filling the room.

WATCH OUT

Old batches go down the drain to freshen it on the way out.

METHOD 4

Dryer sheets in vents and drawers

HOW

- Unscented sheets with 3 or 4 drops of your own oil
- Wedge one at the edge of a return air grille, not inside the duct
- One per drawer, between couch cushions, in shoe bins
- Swap monthly, sooner near a hot vent

WHERE IT WORKS

A sheet on the return vent carries the scent through every register in the house.

WATCH OUT

Do not let a sheet get pulled into the ductwork or lie flat against a filter.

METHOD 5

Warm vanilla

HOW

- 2 or 3 drops of pure vanilla extract on a cool incandescent bulb, then switch it on
- No incandescent bulb: a small ceramic dish with a few drops on a warm lamp base or radiator shelf

WHERE IT WORKS

An entryway right before people arrive. Fades within an hour or two.

WATCH OUT

Pure extract only; imitation goes plasticky. Never on LED, halogen, CFL or anything with exposed wiring.

METHOD 6

Scented baking soda for carpets

HOW

- 1 cup baking soda with about 15 drops essential oil in a lidded container, shaken
- Rest 24 hours so the oil soaks in evenly
- Sprinkle over carpet, rugs and fabric furniture, 15 to 20 minutes
- Vacuum slowly in two directions, empty the canister

WHERE IT WORKS

Pet and smoke odor in carpet. The only method here that pulls odor out instead of covering it.

WATCH OUT

Keep the layer thin. Set in urine may need two rounds, and if it survives that the smell is in the pad.

METHOD 7

Eucalyptus in the shower

HOW

- A fresh bundle tied to the shower head with twine or a rubber band
- Leaves just outside the direct spray, in the steam
- Replace every two to three weeks, when a crushed leaf stops smelling

WHERE IT WORKS

The bathroom, while the shower runs. Cooling menthol that helps in allergy season.

WATCH OUT

Out of the stream or it goes slimy. Run the fan afterward so it dries between showers.

METHOD 8

Frozen citrus cubes for the disposal

HOW

- Chopped lemon, lime and orange peel in an ice cube tray, topped with white vinegar, frozen
- 2 or 3 cubes down the disposal with cold water running
- Twice a week

WHERE IT WORKS

A sour kitchen smell that lives in the grinding chamber. The ice scours, the citrus cuts the grease.

WATCH OUT

Cold water, not hot. Hot water melts fat and lets it recoat the chamber. Fingers clear of the switch.

METHOD 9

Dried coffee grounds

HOW

- Used grounds spread on a baking sheet until fully dry
- A shallow open bowl in the problem zone
- Swap every one to two weeks, sooner in humid spots
- Living areas: add 3 drops of vanilla to the dish

WHERE IT WORKS

Fridge funk, litter box, musty garage, shoe rack. Absorbs fish, garlic and smoke without adding perfume.

WATCH OUT

Grounds must be bone dry or they mold. Keep bowls out of reach of dogs.

METHOD 10

Reed diffuser for pennies

HOW

- 1/4 cup light carrier oil, sweet almond or fractionated coconut
- 20 to 25 drops essential oil
- 2 tablespoons rubbing alcohol so it climbs the reeds
- 5 to 8 rattan reeds, flipped every three or four days

WHERE IT WORKS

Steady background scent for four to six weeks. Lavender in bedrooms, citrus in the kitchen, eucalyptus in the bath.

WATCH OUT

Stable shelf away from pets and children. The oil stains fabric and is not safe to drink. Wipe the neck when you flip the reeds.

ROOM BY ROOM

Match the scent to the room

Entry	Something warm: vanilla or cinnamon, so it reads as comfort at the door
Kitchen and bathrooms	Bright citrus
Bedrooms	Calming lavender
Bath, shower on	Eucalyptus
Any room	Twenty drops per cup of water or half cup of soda is the ceiling. More reads as chemical.

BEFORE ANY OF IT

Fix the smell before you add a smell

- Trash out every single night.
- Windows open for ten minutes each morning.
- A simmer pot over a damp mop or a full bin only layers a note on top. Find the source first.
- Pure essential oils, not fragrance oils. Fragrance oils fade faster and are the usual cause of headaches in a closed room.

KEEP IN MIND

Pets, flames and bulbs

Cats and dogs	Tea tree, eucalyptus and peppermint are toxic to pets. Check each oil before diffusing it regularly, and keep diffusers and coffee grounds out of reach.
Simmer pots	Lowest heat, in sight, off before you leave or sleep.
Bulbs	Vanilla on a cool incandescent only. A ceramic dish near a warm surface is the safe version.
Children	Sprays, diffuser oil and neat oils out of reach. Undiluted oil irritates skin and is dangerous if swallowed.